

SUSHIL KUMAR SHINDE

Power

Grip On Power | Asked to fight a losing battle against Bhairon Singh Shekhawat for the post of vice-president, dispatched from active politics and sent to the Hyderabad Raj Bhavan or pitchforked into Mumbai as chief minister of Maharashtra, Shinde has always done the party's bidding. A cabinet minister in Maharashtra from 1974 to 1992, Shinde has never really been out of the inner circle of the party.

RAVISH SAHANI



Priorities

- Add 1,00,000 MW to the grid by 2012.
- Task force of experts to clear last-mile hurdles in projects.
- Ensure fuel linkage—coal, gas and LNG—through a fuel linkage policy.
- Push BHEL to ramp up capacity for turbines for which plants have to wait for 18 months now.
- Finalise five more ultra mega power plants, based on pitheads.

Is he the one? With nine budgets under his belt as Maharashtra's finance minister, Shinde recognises the implications of inadequate power but could not propel investments in the last tenure. Unless he gets state governments to deliver on issues ranging from land allocation to water to last-mile hurdles, he will be bearing the cross for the crippling power outages across India.

Style statement

Cotton *dhoti-kurta*, never seen without a smile.

▼ 50%



REUBEN SINGH

MURLI DEORA

Petroleum and Natural Gas

Oil's Well Here | Few in the Congress can claim to have known three generations of the Nehru-Gandhi family. Murli Deora can. The ultimate networker, he knows everyone worth knowing, from billionaires to senators to future prime ministers. In or out of Parliament, he has been instrumental in effecting change, whether it was the opening up of insurance or the migration of mobile operators from the licence fee regime to the revenue-sharing platform. In the Licence Raj when Congressmen swore by socialism, he was a votary of the free market. Yet, when crude prices touched \$147 per barrel last year, he refused to raise domestic prices. Deora does not see any contradiction. To him, the Government's economic objective to keep inflation low was aligned with the political need to protect consumers.

Priorities

- Ramp up LPG coverage from the largely urban 110 million homes to reach consumer homes in rural areas.
- Open petro pricing within a band and deploy subsidies only when crude prices cross, say, \$80 per barrel.
- Create a 10-year roadmap for city gas services.
- Acquire oil and gas exploration assets abroad.
- Improve pace of investment in oil, gas and carbon bed methane blocks in India.

Is he the one? Deora has the ability to balance politics and free market economics but could not free the sector from the crippling subsidy raj. Could push ideas on the table and the PM's will, but is unlikely to initiate aggressive reforms.

Style statement

His trademark grey trousers and crisp linen shirts. Doesn't wear khadi.

▼ 45%